UK SAFETY CAMERA NETWORK LTD

Footage Access, Disclosure & Retention Policy

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Effective date	Date of publication (not yet recorded)
Policy owner	Data Protection Officer
Scope	USCN community CCTV network and related footage handling

Approval status: The Data Protection Officer formally approved version 1.0 without conditions on 19 October 2026. The publication and effective date will be recorded separately.

1. Purpose and legal framework

This policy governs access to, retrieval, preservation, export, disclosure, retention and secure disposal of CCTV footage controlled by UK Safety Camera Network Ltd (USCN). It applies to USCN's community CCTV network, including cameras hosted on third-party premises. Hosting does not confer ownership or automatic footage access.

Processing must comply with the UK GDPR, Data Protection Act 2018 and applicable law. USCN-POL-001 and the DPO-approved overarching legitimate interests framework USCN-LIA-001 (approved 19 October 2026) inform this policy. Neither document grants blanket permission to activate individual cameras: camera-specific DPIAs, balancing decisions, safeguards and authorisation remain prerequisites.

2. Access roles and permissions

The DPO may authorise access for the DPO, designated USCN personnel, the Managing Director and technical personnel. Access is not automatic by job title. Each person must have individual credentials and a documented operational need; access is limited to footage and functions required for their approved responsibilities.

Community camera hosts have no automatic right to view, search, download or export footage. The DPO may approve tightly limited host access case by case, with the justification, permitted functions, controls, misuse response and withdrawal mechanism documented in the camera-specific DPIA. Such access may be withdrawn when no longer justified or where misuse occurs.

3. Permitted access purposes

A reasonable, documented operational justification is required before accessing recordings. Permitted purposes include investigating reported crime or antisocial behaviour; responding to emergencies, safeguarding or public safety concerns; processing lawful disclosure and rights requests; necessary technical diagnostics; preserving evidence; investigating complaints; and authorised audits or security investigations.

Limited routine operational checks are permitted for defined purposes such as checking recording quality. Casual browsing, personal curiosity, unauthorised monitoring and access outside approved duties are prohibited. Every footage access must be logged with the person, date/time, purpose and footage concerned.

4. External requests and disclosure

Requests may be considered from police and competent authorities, emergency services, individuals exercising data protection rights, courts or legally entitled parties, authorised representatives, camera hosts and other members of the public. A request does not create an automatic entitlement to footage. USCN generally does not disclose directly to insurers; requests by properly authorised representatives of individuals are assessed individually.

The DPO authorises external disclosures. Police requests ordinarily require a formal written request; urgency may justify an alternative verified channel. USCN verifies requester identity, legal justification, purpose, necessity and proportionality. Emergency disclosure is considered only where required by law or justified by an applicable lawful basis and the circumstances are documented; the DPO's authorisation role remains the default.

Each request and decision record must include requester and verification, purpose, lawful basis, footage scope, decision and approver, recipient, secure transfer method, receipt information, reasons for refusal or partial release and any emergency review. Disclosures must be limited to what is necessary.

5. Exports, transfers and evidential integrity

Only the DPO, specifically authorised USCN personnel, authorised technical personnel or the Managing Director where separately authorised may export footage. Maintain an original or unaltered evidential master, preserve available timestamps and metadata, record the exporter/date/time/range/reason, and clearly distinguish redacted, edited or converted derivative copies. Maintain a documented chain of custody for every exported item.

Permitted transfer methods include appropriately protected encrypted file transfer, access-controlled secure links, encrypted physical media, verified police evidence portals and appropriately protected email. USCN-branded secure download portals are preferred. The DPO sets access protections, including password requirements, proportionate to risk. USB or other physical media are exceptional and require encryption, password protection and documented handover. A link without a password is not inherently approved: the DPO must document why its overall safeguards are adequate.

Assess third-party privacy before release. Apply redaction, clipping, restricted disclosure or other proportionate safeguards where necessary and practicable. Verify the recipient and intended footage before transfer and record custody, delivery and any confirmation of receipt.

6. Ordinary retention and deletion

Original camera recordings are retained for no more than 31 days, and for less where technically practical and justified, then automatically overwritten or deleted unless subject to a valid preservation hold. Ordinary exported and cloud-stored copies are held only for the approved purpose and no longer than 31 days unless an individually justified exception applies.

A recipient of a subject access disclosure may access a secure download link for no more than 31 days from the date the link is issued. Where receipt and access are confirmed earlier, USCN may allow up to three additional days before early restriction, but never beyond the original 31-day expiry. The DPO may require earlier restriction based on risk. Expiry of access does not by itself prove underlying files have been erased.

After access expires or the underlying purpose ends, access is restricted and deletion initiated. A technical/administrative cleanup window of up to 15 days may be needed to delete residual files and copies where no further lawful basis applies; this is not a routine extension of active retention or recipient access. Secure deletion is used where supported, alongside automatic overwriting and documented disposal. Residual copies must be access-restricted during cleanup, with exceptions documented and reviewed.

7. Preservation holds

Preservation may be requested by the DPO, authorised USCN personnel, individuals, police or competent authorities and authorised legal representatives. Requests are assessed against a specific documented lawful purpose. Where footage faces imminent overwrite, authorised staff may impose a temporary hold pending prompt DPO approval.

Preserved footage must be protected from automatic overwriting, accessible only to authorised personnel, and recorded with its reason, footage range, preservation date and authorising officer. The DPO authorises continued preservation, reviews necessity after material developments and at case-appropriate intervals, and authorises release of each hold. No automatic fixed extension applies. When no longer needed, the footage is securely deleted under documented controls.

Possible grounds include police investigations, documented incidents, legal claims or obligations, valid data subject requests and complaints about CCTV operation. A preservation request does not automatically justify indefinite storage.

8. Subject access and representatives

Subject access requests may arrive by email, web form, telephone or written correspondence; no special wording or prescribed form is required. The DPO oversees responses under applicable statutory timescales, normally one calendar month, subject to lawful rules on extensions and clarification.

USCN seeks proportionate information to locate relevant recordings: usually date, approximate time, clothing or appearance description, rough location and camera ID(s) if known. Camera IDs appear on public signage. Absence of an ID alone is not a ground to reject a request. Identity is verified on a risk-based basis where reasonably necessary. Representatives must provide appropriate evidence of authority, assessed case by case.

Third-party privacy and applicable exemptions are assessed before release. Consider redaction, shorter clips, still images or other proportionate measures. Requests should not be refused automatically merely because third parties appear.

9. Refusals, restrictions and complaints

The DPO decides or authorises refusals and partial disclosures. Relevant circumstances may include adverse effects on third-party rights, applicable legal exemptions, non-existent or lawfully deleted footage, unresolved necessary identity checks, requests meeting the legal test for manifestly unfounded or excessive, or protected investigations or system security where an applicable exemption exists. Each ground requires individual legal assessment, not a blanket rule.

USCN provides a clear written explanation and applicable complaint routes, subject to lawful limits. It offers DPO-led reconsideration with impartial or senior-management oversight where practicable. Internal review does not displace rights to complain to the ICO or seek a judicial remedy. Complaints are acknowledged within seven working days.

10. Audit logs and accountability

Log viewing/searching, exports and copies, disclosures and decisions, preservation and releases, manual deletion and disposal, access permission changes, and failed or suspicious attempts where technically recorded. Use system audit trails supplemented by controlled manual records. The DPO reviews records according to risk, incidents, complaints and operational need. Audit logs are retained for at least 12 months, longer where justified by legal or evidential requirements.

Suspected misuse triggers proportionate immediate restriction or suspension, a documented investigation, preservation of relevant evidence, breach assessment and appropriate contractual, disciplinary or legal response. Allegations involving senior personnel receive impartial review; allegations involving the DPO are referred to an external specialist.

11. Revocation and security incidents

Access is withdrawn when a person leaves, changes role, loses a necessary authorisation or condition, when a temporary permission expires, when host access ceases to be justified, or on suspected misuse or DPO direction. Removal is immediate where risk or misuse is suspected, otherwise prompt when authorisation ends. The DPO authorises revocation; designated technical personnel implement and confirm it.

Suspected footage misuse or compromise must be reported internally within 24 hours of discovery, without delaying urgent escalation. USCN contains the incident, preserves evidence, assesses risk to individuals, determines any required ICO/individual notifications, remediates weaknesses and documents actions. UK GDPR reporting obligations, including the 72-hour ICO reporting requirement where applicable, take precedence over internal targets.

12. Governance, review and publication

The DPO owns, maintains, interprets and formally approves this policy. Review is triggered by material changes to law, technology, operations, significant incidents, complaints or audit findings; no fixed calendar review interval is imposed. Maintain authorisations, disclosure decisions, preservation records, disposal records, audit logs, incident records and policy revision/approval history.

Publish the full approved policy with necessary security-sensitive redactions. The approval date is distinct from the effective date, which is the actual publication date. Publication must not expose access credentials, detailed system weaknesses or other security-sensitive operational information. Record the policy's status in USCN's public compliance

and implementation register when maintained.

13. Document control and approval

Version 1.0 was formally approved by the Data Protection Officer without conditions on 19 October 2026, as confirmed in the approval decision. Publication has not yet been confirmed; record the actual publication/effective date separately and do not backdate publication.

Related documents: USCN-POL-001 CCTV Operations, Privacy & Data Protection Policy; USCN-LIA-001 Community CCTV Legitimate Interests Assessment; relevant camera-specific DPIAs and authorisation records.